actor). But India's trade with ASEAN amounts to a small percentage of China's and is low given the size of its economy and geographical proximity. Although imports of manufactured goods from Vietnam and raw materials from Indonesia have grown, continuing sub-par trade is due in part to competition between India and Southeast Asian economies in critical manufacturing spheres. It has also been compounded by India believing that Southeast Asian countries have not been sensitive enough to its concerns about Chinese dumping while limiting labour mobility. Despite these differences, India can certainly be taking better advantage of its goodwill and cultural links by boosting educational exchanges for Southeast Asian students, promoting tourism from Southeast Asia, improving direct air connectivity, increasing cultural centres, and facilitating film distribution.

It does not help that physical connectivity between India and Southeast Asia has also been marred by traditionally poor Indian delivery and project management. Efforts have been made in recent years to try to rectify some of this. A few initiatives are of particular importance. The first is the India–Myanmar–Thailand (IMT) Trilateral Friendship Highway, meant to connect northeast Asia to Thailand. The second effort is the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project, which connects Sittwe on the Bay of Bengal coast in Myanmar with the Indian state of Mizoram. This project has struggled with poor cost estimates and implementation. Although severely complicated by the political and security situation in Myanmar, these efforts could increase trade and connectivity between India and Southeast Asia, and also better connect and develop India's North-East. [34] Beyond such specific efforts, attempts at improving connectivity will require better customs and immigration arrangements and regulatory harmonization.

On balance, much headway has been made with respect to diplomacy and institution building between India and Southeast Asia. From prior neglect and suspicion, important strides have been made over the past three decades on security cooperation with Singapore, Vietnam, Myanmar, Indonesia, Thailand, the Philippines and Malaysia, although there is room for considerable growth subject to the comfort levels of these countries. In part, Southeast Asian states may need to better communicate what kind of